

Edited by
WELFORD BEATON

THE FILM SPECTATOR

15 CENTS
PER COPY

Published In Hollywood Every Other Saturday

Vol. 2

Hollywood, Calif

February 5, 1927

No. 11

IN THIS NUMBER

CLARENCE BROWN MAKES A PICTURE WHICH
PROMPTS US TO COMMENT ON AT LENGTH

ERICH POMMER'S PLACE IN PICTURES, AND OUR
SYSTEM'S REFUSAL TO RECOGNIZE GENIUS

WILLIAM K. HOWARD GIVES US A PRODUCTION THAT
WILL ATTRACT WIDESPREAD INTEREST

SOME THINGS THAT COLLEEN MOORE'S LATEST
TEACHES US ABOUT MAKING PICTURES

ELINOR GLYN WRITES A STORY WHICH REVEALS THAT
SHE HAS A SENSE OF HUMOR

HOOT GIBSON HAS A PREVIEW UPON WHICH WE MAKE
SOME RAMBLING REMARKS

WILL THIS YEAR PRODUCE THE MAN WHO WILL MAKE
PICTURES SENSIBLY?

FLESH AND THE DEVIL
BARBED WIRE
FAUST
WHITE GOLD

TWINKLETOES
IT
THE DENVER DUDE
THE CANADIAN

LETTERS FROM READERS

THE YOUTHFUL CRITIC

THE FILM SPECTATOR

EVERY OTHER SATURDAY

Published by

FILM SPECTATOR, INCORPORATED
WELFORD BEATON, President and Editor

6713 SUNSET BLVD., HOLLYWOOD GRANITE 6346

EDITORIAL

6600 LELAND WAY HEMPSTEAD 8330

*Subscription price, \$3.50 per year
Single copy, 15 cents.*

*The only publication conducted solely for those who
THINK about motion pictures.*

HOLLYWOOD, CALIF., FEBRUARY 5, 1927

Coming Up

Old Ironsides will be reviewed in the next Spectator. Also we will endeavor in that issue to uplift the screen by pointing out lessons to be learned from *The Flaming Frontier*, *The Night of Love*, the latest Banky-Colman production; *New York, Kid Brother*, *Everybody's Acting*, *The Snarl of Hate*, *Summer Bachelors*, and any others that defy us by coming to the neighborhood houses which we patronize. If any reckless producer invites us to a preview, we will include it, too.

* * *

Clarence Brown Scores a Triumph

NOW that *Flesh and Blood* is being shown here there will be a general doffing of hats to Clarence Brown. It is one of M.-G.-M.'s program pictures which was kept within its cost and shooting schedules, but it is the only picture that ever played four weeks at the Capitol, New York. Judging solely by my conception of motion picture art I think it is the best thing that Metro ever gave us. It will not have the appeal of *The Big Parade* or *The Fire Brigade*, but is a better piece of work than either of them. It is a director's picture. Give Ben Glazer credit for having written a splendid story, and Greta Garbo and Jack Gilbert credit for doing the best work of their careers, and still the major honors for the superb production go to the director. When Brown gave us *The Goose Woman* he demonstrated his right to be considered among the greatest American directors. *Flesh and the Devil* raises him still higher. Judging him by both pictures, I could offer no argument in rebuttal if you proclaimed him the greatest. *Flesh and the Devil* is as colorful and elaborate as *The Goose Woman* is drab and sordid. Both are highly emotional and in both the emotions are handled with the sureness and sincerity of a master. Brown is a good director and is going to be a better one because he is not hampered by any of the motion picture traditions beyond which the imaginations of most of our other directors can not soar. He simply tells his story, with the writing of which he always has a

great deal to do. Something of his training as an engineer is reflected in the systematic efficiency with which he moves from scene to scene in a story that flickers by without a superfluous foot. But his understanding of human emotions is something that can not be learned at an institution that specializes in producing engineers. In depicting them on the screen he ignores the factor of safety that enters into bridge building. Each emotion is strong enough only to carry its share of the burden of the story. There is no waste energy, not a gesture more than is necessary to make a perfect scene. But there is vigor in Brown's repression, the vigor of a red blood that is pulsing deeply, the surface ruffled only enough to indicate the storm within. It is the kind of direction that makes actors great. More than any other American director, Clarence Brown invests a picture with the proper atmosphere to match the mood of the story. In *Flesh and the Devil* he displays a pictorial sense comparable only with the qualities in Pommer's pictures that made them popular here. The production is extraordinary for the beauty of its scenes and the businesslike connection between the scenes and the action. Although his characters belong to the titled, wealthy class they are not forever tripping over servants. Occasionally you see a maid or a butler who is necessary to maintain the atmosphere of the story or assist the action, but never anything to cover up a lapse in the story or to provide scenic effects that bear no relation to the story. Brown's production in this picture is like the exquisite work of a master book-binder whose are registers on the cover the mood of the story which the book contains.

* * *

Clarence Scorns Movie Traditions

BEFORE dismissing the externals of *Flesh and the Devil* I would like to pay my respects to Clarence Brown's proficiency in handling ensemble shots. Greta Garbo and Gilbert meet in a park without disturbing the park activity. It is staged splendidly. Strollers pass between the characters and the camera, a policeman saunters by, a perambulator almost runs over Gilbert's toes, in the dim background two saddle horses cross the scene, a man leads a dog across the foreground—dozens of things happen that make you feel that the whole thing is real, but not one thing that distracts your attention from the lovers on the bench. Anyone who has been in a European railway station lives the experience over again in this picture. Brown is not too busy with his drama in the foreground to overlook the background in which a porter touches his hat to the station master, a man hails a cab and a woman collects her luggage. It is easy enough to put action in an ensemble shot, but Brown puts it in a manner that is convincing. He applies his engineering efficiency to the story itself. He does not bother us with non-essentials. The opening sequence takes place in a military institution of some sort in which Gilbert and Lars Hanson are something or other in uniforms. We are not told what the institution is, what the young fellows are doing in it, or even what city or country it is in—and we don't care, for such details have nothing to do with the story. But you know and I know that almost any other director in the business would have opened with a title reading something like this: "In the Bimberger School of Infantry, where German gentlemen are made

into German officers, and situated on the River Rhine, three miles east of Hootsiedoodle, there are two young men, one a son of a Scotch Presbyterian minister, and the other the offspring of a union of a hand-organ grinder and his second cousin."—all of which would have nothing to do with the story, but would be shown in deference to movie traditions. As I said, Brown scoffs at traditions. He puts his characters on a train and never tells us where they are going, or why. It makes no difference, for we go with them and soon learn that they are going home. When he wishes to introduce John Smith he has a character speaking the title, "It's a fine day, John Smith," and we know who John Smith is. But despite the dearth of information that Clarence gives us there is nothing obscure about the story. Everything we need to know to help to an understanding of it is spread before us. It moves by quickly, each scene the logical sequel to the preceding one. There are not a great many titles, as there is no occasion for them, for Brown has the ability to tell a story with action, and to compose beautiful scenes with which to tell it. The photography in *Flesh and the Devil* is a splendid example of the high degree of art that can be reached with the camera, and Brown was fortunate in having such an artist as William Daniels to turn the crank. The art direction of Cedric Gibbons and Frederick Hope enriched the production until it is one of the most satisfying to the discriminating eye that ever have been produced in an American studio.

* * *

"Flesh and Devil" Great Work of Art

BECAUSE I put the leading of a dog across a scene before a reference to the emotions with which *Flesh and the Devil* deals, I do not wish to convey the impression that I consider their relative importance in that order. I merely dismissed the obvious features of the picture before approaching its soul. This picture is great, not for the qualities I have mentioned, but for those I yet have to deal with. It is an inspiring story of a great friendship, a friendship which ennobles two young men and is the biggest thing in their lives. Gradually the screen is learning things it should have known years ago. *Stella Dallas* teaches it that mother love had been a neglected subject. *Beau Geste* teaches it that brotherly love is a good film theme. *Flesh and the Devil* teaches it that there is a good story in friendship. There are a lot of other good themes lying around unused, but one by one they will be clubbed into the heads of producers. Brown never forgets that his picture is the story of a friendship. A passionate love story runs through it, but we never lose sight of the friendship. There is a glorious ending—too good to tell you what it is. But it gives one renewed faith in the future of the magnificent art to the advancement of which *The Spectator* is dedicated and the activities of so many of its readers devoted. The ending is logical, not "happy." Under Brown's direction the acting of the principals is sincere and convincing. Jack Gilbert returns from exile in Africa to find that the woman whom he loves passionately has married his friend. He takes the blow standing up—a magnificent example of acting. He has a smile and a handclasp for his friend. He is true to their youthful pact. But a time comes when he has stood all he can. He lets go, and we have some more acting, equally notable, but greatly different. Greta Garbo

has a similar outburst, human, logical, revealing her powers as they seldom have been revealed. Lars Hanson, always repressed, always the master of his emotions, gives a performance that more firmly fixes his place among real screen actors. George Fawcett, that brilliant veteran who never fails us, gains further laurels in this picture, and Eugenie Besserer is a sympathetic and appealing mother, duplicating the success she achieved in *The Fire Brigade*. Barbara Kent, a winsome young miss, whom I can not recall having seen before, rises to the heights demanded by several strong scenes. *Flesh and the Devil* has some of the best love scenes yet seen on the screen. Clarence Brown has the good taste to stage such scenes in places that provide the lovers with some seclusion. Henry King in *Barbara Worth* has Vilma Banky going into Ronald Colman's arms in full view of a multitude, which not only is bad taste, but is poor drama, for it robs love of the delicious thrill that is accentuated by the privacy that envelops it. There is but one witness to but one of the love scenes between Miss Garbo and Gilbert. Unfortunately for them, but essential to the story, is the fact that the witness is Greta's husband. But I can not go on enumerating the virtues of *Flesh and the Devil*. It would occupy too much space. But I must not overlook a word of praise for Marion Ainslee's titles, which stick strictly to the job of telling the story, even if at times they wander from the path of correct punctuation. Considering the picture as a whole I hereby give it a fixed place on my list of ten best pictures for 1927. It is too much to hope that there will be ten others that would displace it. Months ago I recorded in *The Spectator* my respect for Clarence Brown as a director. That respect has deepened. Only a truly great director could elevate a program picture to one of the greatest works of art ever produced in a motion picture studio. My hat is off to the man who did it.

* * *

Erich Pommer and American Pictures

THE thoughtful person contemplating motion pictures must arrive at the conclusion that the most interesting person connected with them is Erich Pommer. It is Pommer's relation to pictures, not his personality, that makes him interesting. For all I know to the contrary he may have an interesting personality, but it is his works, not the man, that we are interested in. While he was director-general of UFA that organization turned out scores of pictures that had so little merit that they could not be shown at a profit in this country. The company produced pictures so rapidly that it was not humanly possible for Pommer to give personal attention to all of them. At least such is my conclusion after reading in an English paper a review of UFA activities during the last year that Pommer was with it. However, while he was picture-making in Europe Pommer gave personal attention to every detail of the production of six pictures. We have seen five of them in this country—*The Cabinet of Dr. Caligari*, *Last Laugh*, *Variety*, *Waltz Dream*, and *Faust*. The sixth, *Metropolis*, a million dollar production, we are to see. Five different directors made these pictures, but the whole half dozen reflect but one mind, that of Pommer, establishing it as the greatest picture mind in the world. His five pictures that have been shown here have given us a new conception of screen art. Con-

sidered as a group, they are the greatest contribution ever made to the advancement of that art. From the flamboyant treatment of the passionate story in *Variety*, the theatrical use of the camera, consistent with the telling of a theatrical story; to the lofty and inspired treatment of the Faust story, rising to sublime heights to match the majesty of the theme, covers an extraordinary range of expression and fixes the place of the screen among the high arts. Pommer came to Hollywood to make pictures for Famous Players-Lasky, a company in a position to have given him all the intellectual and technical co-operation that a combing of the world would bring to light. Hampered as he was in Europe by the necessity of keeping within the financial restrictions of his organization, he made a record unequalled by any other producer in the world; unhampered in this country he could rise to greater heights and lend still further dignity to screen art. Will he be unhampered? In the answer to that question lies the reason why Erich Pommer is the most interesting man in pictures. That he was hampered is the only possible construction to put on his break with Paramount.

* * *

Can Our System Assimilate Genius?

MOTION pictures are organized in this country so that it is difficult for a definite personality to register itself. Many times in *The Spectator* I have recorded my high opinion of B. P. Schulberg as a producer, and certainly he is one of the finest fellows in the business. He it is under whom Pommer was working in this country. I know of no American who has a better picture mind than Schulberg, but he is part of the American system of making pictures, a multiple mind system that robs productions of all individuality. An American system that does not permit an American unhampered expression on the screen scarcely will readjust itself to grant the privilege to a foreigner. Several times I have charged the industry with an inability to learn by experience. I believe Pommer's success abroad will mean nothing to Hollywood. He was induced to come here on account of his extraordinary achievements in Germany under a certain system, and was expected to duplicate those achievements under another system that was forced on him. His presence here puts on trial our method of making pictures. Can this method assimilate a real artist and allow such artist to express himself? I doubt it. If Pommer's American-made pictures do not possess the merit of those he made in Germany it will be our system's fault, for the six pictures that I enumerated in the preceding paragraph remove any doubt of his ability. We have several one-picture men in this country, but none who has turned out six which have arrested the attention of the world. Pommer has supervised two pictures here, *Hotel Imperial* and *Barbed Wire*, both starring Pola Negri. The former is the better motion picture, but the latter will have greater audience appeal. While both will rank among the foremost pictures of the year, neither comes up to the standard set by *The Last Laugh*, *Variety* or *Faust*. They do not possess the same artistic appeal as the German-made ones and will not be regarded as such valuable contributions to screen art. But in the two, in which he had the assistance of such capable directors as Mortiz Stiller and Rowland Lee, Pommer reveals to us

again the brilliancy of Pola Negri as an actress. That much he has done, something that American directors without his supervision have been unable to do in the years that have elapsed between the arrivals of Pola and Pommer in this country. He also has made his two pictures notable for the pictorial excellence that characterized those which he made abroad. That both of them would have been better pictures if he had been allowed the same freedom he enjoyed in Germany seems a reasonable presumption.

* * *

One That Pommer Made in Hollywood

BARBED WIRE is a succession of beautiful scenes, exquisite works of art such as Pommer always uses in telling his stories. Bert Glennon's camera work reaches the high degree of excellence he achieved in *Hotel Imperial*. The lighting is particularly effective and Rowland Lee is to be commended for his sense of composition. The direction all the way through is masterly. One sequence is particularly notable for its depth of human appeal. It opens with a shot showing the German and French soldiers fraternizing in No Man's Land, the spell of the Christmas spirit blotting out animosities engendered by the war. Later we see how the prison camp celebrates Christmas, the whole sequence being handled in an impressive manner. The story of *Barbed Wire* is an adaptation by Jules Furthman of Hall Caine's "A Woman of Knockelov". The original is a story of an English girl falling in love with a German incarcerated in a prison camp on the Isle of Man. The picture places the camp in France and makes the girl French, keeping Pola Negri more in character, as there is nothing about her to suggest the English. She gives a remarkable performance, responding nobly to Lee's direction. Pola is a superb actress. The story sags in the middle, probably due more to faulty editing than to any weakness in the story itself. There is nothing the matter with the scenes, for there is not a poorly presented sequence in the whole production, but for perhaps a reel there is little to hold the interest of an audience which derives its entertainment from the story and none from beautiful scenes capably directed. Undoubtedly a great deal of thought was expended on the ending, and while I did not like it, I can not suggest how it could have been improved. Inherently the ending has great strength. Her neighbors are incensed at the French girl for declaring her love for the German, splendidly played by Clive Brook, who is ideal in the part, and are on the point of driving her from home when her brother, blinded in the war, appears. The physically sightless man is the only one who can see the folly of the senseless antagonism, and he makes a long speech, broken into several titles, that are good propaganda, but poor motion picture entertainment. It makes the ending drag. But the picture as a whole is a splendid example of screen art, notwithstanding its few deficiencies, and demonstrates the wisdom of Paramount's action in securing the great picture mind of Erich Pommer to supervise its foreign players, and the folly of not retaining him to continue it. Clyde Cooke plays a comedy party in a manner that makes it one of the big features of the picture. Those splendid artists, Claude Gillingwater and Gustav von Seyffertitz contribute perfect performances, and Einar Hanson, as Pola's brother, adds to the

merits of the picture. There is one extraordinary shot showing the dead traversing a cloudy thoroughfare that is a monument to the technical genius of Roy Pomeroy.

* * *

One That Pommer Made in Germany

FAUST is the work of an unrestrained Pommer, working under a system which he dominated. It is a magnificent achievement, with a depth of spirituality which American producers seldom attain. It is too intellectual to match *Barbed Wire* in audience appeal, consequently under the industry's dollar standard it will be rated as inferior to that picture, but if I were in the producing business I would rather have to my credit one Faust than a dozen *Barbed Wires*. A picture like Faust adds to the hardships of a reviewer's life. It makes our ordinary run of pictures appear so trivial. To consider it and *Twinkletoes* as products of the same method of expression is to put the Colleen Moore picture under a heavy load. I have seen quite a number of pictures since I viewed Faust and I looked at all of them with the eyes that beheld the majesty of the German production, while still under the spell of that extraordinary artistic triumph and with the new conception of the screen that it gave me. It has created within me a feeling of discontent with our factory-made product that might have entertained me if I had not seen Faust. But Faust itself is not without blemish. Like *Barbed Wire*, it sags in the middle, but when the real tragedy of its love story begins to develop, it sweeps onward to a great ending in a manner that earns my unbounded respect for the picture mind responsible for it. It is a simple love story that might have had Hollywood for its locale, or Amsterdam or Calcutta, but it has the glamour of an old-time setting, the romance of clothes that used to be worn, story-book architecture and scenery that an artist dreamed. The major fault of Faust is that it is done too well. There is so much of it that it over-feeds the aesthetic sense and dulls the power of appreciation. I believe the ideal way to see it would be to make two trips, viewing half of it one night and half the next. It would tend to better digestion of its merits. Like all the Pommer pictures, including the two he has made here, it reveals an extraordinary blending of beauty and drama. There is not a shot in Faust that is not a wonderful example of composition, lighting and photography used effectively to maintain the atmos-

phere of the production and to advance the story. I can not recall the exact words in the main title which characterize Faust as a poem in pictures, or something to that effect. That is exactly what it is—an exquisite piece of poetry, related on the screen by its master poet, and to enjoy it to the uttermost you must so regard it. It is more than a drama of a great love, more than a story of supreme emotion. It is a product of the newest art that unfolds to us the limitless possibilities of that art when its expression is left to the free exercise of a brain that understands more than any other the extent of the possibilities.

* * *

"Faust" Has Great Intellectual Appeal

FAUST was directed by F. W. Murnau, who directed *The Last Laugh* also. In this country we know of nothing notable he has done without Pommer's supervision. He is making a picture in Hollywood for Fox and not until it is released can we measure his real ability as a director. All we know of his work here thus far is that he already has exceeded his shooting schedule by a couple of months or so and is proceeding cautiously. We know that Du Pont, made famous as the director of *Variety*, failed deplorably in his first effort to make a picture in Hollywood without Pommer's co-operation. The most notable work of five different foreign directors being under Pommer's supervision makes logical the conclusion that the chief credit for the notable work must belong to him. I credit him with the virtues of Faust as I have no way of knowing how much Murnau contributed to them. M.-G.-M., in Americanizing Faust, failed to give Pommer any credit for it, his name not appearing on the screen. Even Paramount, which had him under contract, omits giving him screen credit for supervising *Barbed Wire*. The immensity of the letters that record Rowland Lee's name as its director perhaps left no room for the mention of Pommer as supervisor. It is called a Lee-Pommer production, without stating what Pommer had to do with it, an oversight that did not embrace the art director, photographer and others. Probably nothing smaller, nothing betraying the characteristic meanness of some of our picture minds, than Metro's deliberate slighting of Pommer's contribution to Faust, ever has disgraced an art. But when we compare Pommer with those responsible for the slight it becomes laughable. If some of the people who control American pictures had a sense of humor they would die laughing at themselves. Emil Jannings' characterization in *The Last Laugh* was not such as to develop all the sympathy the part might have called forth, but in Faust he gives a magnificent performance that is comparable with the best work of our American actors. Camila Horn is the Marguerite of our dreams—young, blonde and beautiful, so unlike the hefty sopranos who generally sing the part. The Faust of Gustav Eckmann is in every way adequate. But it is not the acting that makes Faust a great picture. It is the extraordinary breadth of the conception, the amazing production given it and the intellectual treatment of the theme. Even those who think the story drags can not fail to be impressed by the artistic qualities of the picture, and its appearance on American screens will have a tendency to make us demand similar excellence in the works of our own studios. That Paramount realized this

An established reputation for handling the greatest variety of the finest silks.



BOLGER'S

6510-6514 HOLLYWOOD BOULEVARD

7615 SUNSET BOULEVARD

was indicated by its action in securing Pommer, Jannings and other foreigners, but that under the American system Pommer would be able to duplicate here the triumphs he achieved abroad I never for a moment believed. Art, to achieve its ultimate, must be the free expression of its creator, and the wisdom of allowing an intellect to express itself freely on the screen is something that we not yet have learned in this country. When we grow big enough to learn it Pommer may give us an American-made **Faust**.

* * *

Screen's Progress Helped by Germans

WHATEVER advancement has been made in the technic, lighting and photographing of motion pictures during the past ten years has been the work of Germans. Only a few of their pictures have been outstanding successes in this country because they devoted most of their attention to the science of picture-making, and little to the entertainment value of their stories. Meanwhile in this country the reverse has been the rule. We give all our attention to stories and so little to the method of presenting them that all of them are alike. Pommer came to this country two years ago, went through our studios, noted our way of doing things and then returned home and so improved upon our methods that he has sent us the best half dozen pictures standing to the credit of any man in the world. In our studios we have people capable of doing everything that Pommer has done, but they are not allowed to do it and our pictures are kept down to the dead level of the capacity of our supervisors, not more than two or three of whom know anything about pictures. In any other line of human endeavor the coming of such a master as Pommer would have been welcomed cordially by those whose co-worker he was to be. He would have received the heartiest cooperation of those who were in a position to profit from contact with him or from observation of the results he accomplished. But the motion picture business is like none other on earth. When Pommer arrived he was not allowed to do the things he was brought over here to do. There is nothing else to deduce from his split with Paramount. I know nothing of the inside story of the disagreement. All I know is what I read in the papers, statements by both the studio and Pommer to the effect that they parted with the most cordial relations still existing between them, giving us occasion to thank the man who thought up the new meaning for the word "applesauce". I have no personal interest in Pommer, the individual. But I am interested in Pommer, the artist, because he is the biggest artist that pictures have produced. It was unthinkable that he should turn his back on Hollywood and by returning to Germany proclaim to the world that this community, that prides itself on being the film capital of the world, has no place within its borders for the greatest film mind in the world. It is to the credit of the industry that Pommer no sooner had left Paramount than he was deluged with offers of other alliances.

* * *

Every day or so I read that some film player, who is a subscriber to *The Spectator*, has left for the East to make a picture. I would like all of them to know that it is no trouble for us to forward their *Spectators* to them while they are away.

Has All the Things That Screen Can't Do

ANY producer will give you a list of the things you can not do on the screen. The list is getting shorter. *Stella Dallas*, removed mother love from among the things the public simply won't stand for; *Beau Geste* blotted out brotherly love and *Flesh and the Devil* will wipe friendship off the list. Among the remaining things that you can not do is the assembling of three men and a woman on a dust-laden ranch in Arizona during a drought, and in three interiors and a few drab exteriors work out a story that will interest anyone. Any producer will tell you that that can't be done and he would be apt to shoot any author who submitted such a story. However, William K. Howard tackled such a story and has made a picture that will create a lot of talk. He has done all the impossible things, but if *White Gold* is not a success it will surprise me. Briefly, this is the story: Kenneth Thompson marries Jetta Goudal and takes her to his father's ranch. The father, George Nichols, hates her; George Bancroft comes along as a ranch hand; the drought continues; the springs on Nichol's rocking chair creak; there is dust on everything; nerves are taut; Bancroft enters Jetta's room at night when the husband is absent; she shoots him; the father, knowing his son will believe him and not his wife, says that he shot Bancroft, having discovered him in Jetta's room. Jetta is silent. Saddened because her husband did not have enough faith in her to make it unnecessary for her to defend herself, she leaves the ranch—and that is the end of the story. To make a picture out of it was a brave thing for Bill Howard to attempt, and he scores a signal success even though he does not get all the possibilities out of the story. Perhaps Garrett Fort and Tay Garnett did not write everything into the story that might have been written in. They did not make the most of the real menace in the story—the drought, nor did they dramatize the rain when the drought ends. But I saw the picture in a projection-room and I believe some things were done to it after I viewed it, so I had better be careful in criticizing it for lacking something it may now contain. *White Gold* is a picture that is a distinct contribution to the science of making pictures. Howard takes impossible scenes and situations and makes a thoroughly intelligent picture out of them. It is a picture that no student of the screen can afford to miss. It reflects the greatest credit on Howard. He is one of our youngest directors, but he is going to be heard from. He is too much in love with his work to fail at it. He has intelligence and daring, and the daring director is the only one who will do things of value to the screen as an art. Howard even was daring enough to direct Jetta Goudal—once.

* * *

"White Gold" Was A Bold Undertaking

WHITE GOLD was a bold undertaking because it is a story solely of emotions, its characters restricted to one spot, and with no action in it. The biggest scene is one showing Jetta, Nichols and Thompson sitting at a table. Howard directs them with rare intelligence. They scarcely move, holding your interest only by the expressions on their faces, with the help of an occasional title when one is necessary to assist in the

interpretation of their thoughts. In such a scene, of course, close-ups are necessary, but Howard does not overdo them as nearly all directors do. *White Gold* would have been a still better picture if there had been a more accommodating actress in the only feminine role. Jetta Goudal has ability, but she exercises it only in close-ups. I do not know what is going to happen to her when all the directors on the De Mille lot in turn have directed her, for none of them will take her on a second time. She has a perverted sense of her importance in the screen world, or such a queer conception of her obligations to her employers that no picture in which she appears is as good as it would be if some sensible person of even less ability played her part. Her ability not being outstanding, I can not understand why any producer bothers with her. I expect to be invited to a grand celebration on the De Mille lot to mark the termination of her contract. The acting honors in *White Gold* belong to George Nichols, the veteran character actor. His hatred for his son's bride is unreasonable; he is morose and taciturn, and continually rocks in his squeaky chair in a maddening manner. Nichols gives a splendid interpretation of such a character, being particularly effective in one long close-up in which he registers his fear of looking his daughter-in-law in the eye. Young Thompson is an acceptable leading man, being sincere and convincing. George Bancroft handles his part with his usual thoroughness, but in his last sequence would have looked better if he had not used the greasy make-up similar to that which makes McLaglen and Lowe look almost disgusting in *What Price Glory?* I suppose this repulsive make-up means something to somebody, but to me it is only something that spoils a scene. Bancroft starts off on an amorous adventure with his face almost dripping with 'grease, a queer fancy for the wooing of someone else's bride. On aesthetic as well as moral grounds Jetta had a valid excuse for shooting him. Clyde Cook adds some fine comedy touches to the picture. Anton Grot, the art director, dresses the production in a garb that matches its mood, and John W. Krafft and John Farrow contribute a set of satisfactory titles. The production was supervised by C. Gardner Sullivan, edited by Jack Dennis and photographed by Lucien Andriott. Marion Orth's continuity was a fine piece of work. *White Gold* is somewhat revolutionary and is done so well that it suggests a brilliant future for Bill Howard. Unless I miss my guess he is a young man who will go a long way.

* * *

"Twinkletoes" Is Shy on Twinkles

TWINKLETOES was well underway when I dropped in on it. The first scene I saw was one in which Warner Oland was attempting to get the best of Colleen Moore. I did not know what it was all about, but I was impressed by the acting of Colleen in the struggle which followed. She lets herself go and expresses fear and hate with all the passion a Negri could put into a scene. It is a bit good enough for the most dramatic production. Oland, of course, is fine in it—a habit he has. Then followed a glimpse of that splendid character actor, Lucien Littlefield, and in a few more feet came the end. Plenty of action, capable direction, good lighting and photography, a fine cast—and yet I had heard that *Twinkletoes* was a very poor picture. What I had seen

of it certainly gave me the impression that it was well worth while, and I awaited the front end of it with confidence. When finally I had seen all of it I discovered that all its virtues are in its last reel. Taken as a whole it is an extremely tiresome picture, worse than anything else in which Colleen has appeared. The locale being the Limehouse district in London, it is as foreign to us as the scenes in which *Faust* is played. There is as much story in it as there is in *Variety* or *The Waltz Dream*. First National has money enough to secure the best of everything for a Colleen Moore production, and Colleen can act quite well enough to keep up her end in any company. Why, then, did John McCormick fail to give us a picture that would measure up with Pommer's best? The answer is easy. Pommer applies intellect to his pictures and *Twinkletoes* is a product of established movie methods. No picture that was the result of deep thinking could contain so many senseless close-ups as *Twinkletoes* contains. They were quite enough in themselves to spoil any production. Whoever was responsible for them does not understand the fundamentals of making pictures, nor has he any sense of drama. The author wrote a scene describing the manner in which the girl confesses her love for the man. She mounts the steps leading to her home while the man stands at the bottom and urges her to come down to him. She goes a little way, stops, turns, descends a few steps, mounts again, hesitates, then slowly descends and goes into his arms. Directed intelligently it could have been a strong scene. It should have been shown in a long shot without a camera change, the man at the bottom of the stairs, the girl at the top, both at all times in sight of the audience, which is interested only in whether she is going to him and not at all in the expressions on their faces. The important feature of the scene is the relation of the characters to one another. The moment there is a cut to a close-up of either of them this relationship is lost sight of. But the entire scene is shown in close-ups, demonstrating that the makers of the picture did not understand it. This lack of intelligence in the use of close-ups is in evidence throughout the entire production. On every hand you hear Colleen's acting criticized on the score that she smirks and grins too much. The criticism is just, but the fault is not hers. In each of her pictures are dozens of close-ups of her for which there is no excuse whatever. They are lessening her box office value by giving the public a wrong impression of her acting ability. But I suppose we will continue to have them.

* * *

Suffers From a Great Many Ills

A PICTURE made by people who do not know what close-ups are for can not be expected to reveal intelligence in the handling of its less obvious features. *Twinkletoes* has many other weaknesses. There are perhaps a dozen scenes which have nothing to do with the story, and having no virtues in themselves serve only to retard it. The only reason for them that I could see was to provide footage into which could be cut some more close-ups of Colleen. The characterizations of Oland and Littlefield were perfect, but poor Tully Marshall, as Colleen's father, was made to behave as no father on earth ever behaved. Every time he and Colleen got within clinching distance they grabbed one another and hugged

and kissed. I have two daughters for whom I have as much paternal love as a screen father need be endowed with, but if both of them together pawed me half as much as Colleen paws Tully I would take such drastic measures to prevent it that I might become liable to a charge of cruelty. Neither fathers nor daughters act as both are made to do in *Twinkletoes*, direction that makes a large contribution to the general unreality of the picture. A street fight attracts a crowd which does not surround the combatants as an ordinary street crowd would. It leaves one side open for the camera. Charles Brabin, who directed the picture, might ask me how the camera could record the fight if the crowd surrounded it. By having an energetic spectator make the crowd describe a large circle, which could be planted in a long shot, moving the camera within the circle to get the medium shots of the fight. But, in any event, any scene that can not be shown on the screen exactly as it would be in real life never should be photographed. There is a similar lapse in the direction of a theatre sequence. Colleen is doing her stuff on the stage and the excited chorus girls assemble in the wings to watch her. They do not cluster as they would in real life. They stand in parallel lines, to permit a shot being taken between them to register their interest and to show Colleen on the stage in the distance. With the camera stationed in an opposite wing Colleen could have been shown in the foreground and the girls grouped naturally in the background. As the picture has it, it is a striking example of unintelligent direction. The whole theatre sequence is ridiculous. We see all that *Twinkletoes* does on the stage. She dances very nicely, quite well enough to please a tough Limehouse audience, but not well enough to arouse the tremendous and sustained enthusiasm that the audience registers. The picture audience, having seen her act, knows this. And it has nothing to do with the story. Her success or failure as a dancer is not what the story is about. It is all very silly, serving only as an excuse for several more close-ups of Colleen smiling. It may interest Brabin and McCormick to know that men in Limehouse audiences keep their hats on in music halls. In the picture they take them off. And if *Twinkletoes* is such a favorite that men break up the show clamoring for her appearance, how do you explain a title in a previous sequence which says that often there is little in her house to eat? A headliner who is three-sheeted throughout the neighborhood ought to draw down enough to beat Old Mother Hubbard in a cupboard contest. I have pointed out quite enough to show why *Twinkletoes* is not a notable picture. And it might have been. In itself it has everything necessary to the making of a picture out of the ordinary. It falls down because it did not have intelligent treatment.

* * *

Elinor Glyn Picks Winner

WHEN a group of four or five people enters a room it is not unusual that one of them attracts more attention than all the others. All may conduct themselves alike, they may look pretty much alike, wearing clothes of equal attractiveness, but one of them will draw the eyes of the majority of lookers-on. He or she is the one with that strange quality, personality. It is something that no one acquires consciously. It remained for Elinor Glyn to put it on the screen, to dramatize it,

even though undramatically. Perhaps she will do it over again in something bigger and stronger than *It*, which is a delightful comedy, but which only scratches the surface of the possibilities of the theme. Madame Glyn in *It* deals with but one variation of the theme, personality with a sex appeal attachment. At least, I suppose that that is what her "it" is. She seems to have perplexed the world as much as Dr. Einstein did with his theory of relativity. While we don't know what the two of them discovered, we are quite ready to believe in the existence of the things they discovered. But there is a bigger "it" than a shopgirl's which lands her a rich husband. There is the "it" of the man of power, who can do tremendous things by sheer force of his personality. A strong drama could be based on it, and I hope Madame Glyn undertakes to write it, for she should not allow anyone else to exploit her discovery. When she first thought of the story for the picture *It* she told it to Ben Schulberg. He thought it a great idea and told her to go ahead. He assigned Clarence Badger to direct it. Badger took to the idea enthusiastically. So far, so good. Then a peculiar thing arose. No one else on the Paramount lot could see any merit in the idea, which, in essence, was to make a motion picture about the thing motion picture artists must have to make motion pictures successful—personality. The selling end of the organization in New York thought it a nutty idea and opposed the making of such a picture. But Madame Glyn, Schulberg and Badger stuck stubbornly to their conviction that they had a winner, and it has turned out that they were right. It is interesting chiefly for revealing to us a new Elinor Glyn, one with an amusing taste in comedy and who can entertain us for the full length of a feature picture that does not have a single tiger skin in it. It adds strength to my argument in the last *Spectator* that Madame Glyn has a picture mind and that the screen is a better medium of expression for her than literature. We always will get better pictures from writers who have learned screen technic than from screen technicians who try to write.

* * *

Nothing in "It" to Make You Mad

DEALING with the subject of authors in pictures in the last issue, I said that when authors supervised the making of pictures based on their stories we would have no more pictures that would make us mad, even though there might be many that we do not like. Such pictures would be free from all the absurdities that are so much in evidence now. It is a picture supervised by the writer of its story and there is nothing in it that affronts the intelligence. Even those who do not like it can not charge it with being illogical, silly or senseless, ills which afflict so many screen offerings. But I can not imagine anyone not liking it. The story has been told many times before on the screen, but this time it has been motivated differently and the whole thing has been treated so intelligently that it is delightful entertainment. Of course there are the usual senseless close-ups, which can be attributed to the editing and not to the story or the direction. Tony Moreno, William Austin and the captain of a yacht stand close together on deck and talk. It is shown entirely in close-ups, losing all its pictorial value. A group of three smartly dressed men on the deck of a trim yacht gives the cameraman an opportunity to pro-

duce an artistic scene, but if he made such a shot it was discarded in favor of some close-ups that mean nothing whatever. In another scene two women call on Tony in his office and to bring the three of them within a medium shot Clarence Badger packs them together on the side of the desk where Tony sits and where visitors to his office would not go. They would face him across the desk. You will notice in any picture that Erich Pommer makes the characters are grouped naturally and the camera has to shoot the scene any way it can. Most American directors do their grouping to accommodate the camera, which is why we have so many things that look just like motion pictures, instead of the bits of real life that Pommer gives us. In all the rest of his direction Badger shows that he entered completely into the spirit of the story and he makes a good picture out of it. Clara Bow, of course, is captivating. I can imagine no one else in the part. Moreno never did better in a light role. The beach sequence, in which he and Clara have the time of their lives on the amusement devices, goes over big because the two of them seem really to be enjoying themselves. Badger realized that joy is contagious and directed the sequence in a manner that makes the audience get as much fun out of it as the characters did. But as Clara and Tony played themselves, I believe the acting honors of it belong to William Austin, who played a character part. He has done well in a great many bits without previously having given a casting director the idea that he could do well a lot of bits in one picture. In it he has a big part—in effect a lot of bits—and adds immeasurably to the entertainment value of the picture. It is to be hoped that hereafter he will be recognized as a comedian to be featured. It was quite an inspiration on the part of someone to have Madame Glyn herself appear in a sequence. It is a touch which in itself will have a lot to do with the success of the picture. There must be many millions of people in the world curious about the appearance of so famous a woman and it will satisfy their curiosity. I wonder if she has “it”.

* * *

“The Denver Dude” Is Rather a Dud

HOOT Gibson's latest is *The Denver Dude*, a Western farce that has precious little to recommend it except Hoot's own good natured personality. No doubt it will appeal to his regular list of customers and perhaps that is all that it is supposed to do. But just why do they make so many Westerns that by no possibility can appeal to people of intelligence? And, if a Western, why not maintain the Western atmosphere? In this picture Blanche Mahaffey, a very dainty little girl, strolls around a corral in gowns that would grace the terrace at Monte Carlo, and lives in a ranch house whose interior would be ostentatious in a Newport cottage. She and her mother, or aunt, or somebody, dress for a barbecue as elaborately as if they were going to be presented at court. I grant that it is good movie stuff to show beautiful gowns, but to make the roasting of an ox the reason for superlative dolling up is a weird bit of movie license. Also we have a Boston man wearing a silk hat on the ranch. And an old man who, a title explains, was born in this country to save the fare over, wears kilts and talks a brand of Scotch that will make it unsafe to show the picture in Scotland. The title writer's conception of

Scotch dialect is something extraordinary. The inviolable rule that you must have the love element in a motion picture is satisfied in *The Denver Dude* with a ready-made romance that required no working up whatever. It just is, although the two parties to it hadn't met since they were children. There is one quaint bit of comedy. A woman looking for her husband is told that he is dead, a funny idea in itself, but it becomes screaming when she is told that he broke his leg and had to be shot. Another good idea in a movie is to have the hero protect the reputation of the heroine. Although there is not the slightest reason why Hoot should not tell the father that the daughter opened the safe and may know what happened to the missing money, he stubbornly refuses to do so, entailing upon himself the necessity of fleeing before the sheriff gets there. Blanche opened the safe to get her necklace for the barbecue, for no refined Western girl would outrage ranch conventions by appearing at a big barbecue without a necklace, but a shot in the barbecue sequence shows her not only minus the necklace, but also without the diamonds and pearls she previously had worn when she went to inspect a bull. Some bandits shoot a bus driver in this picture. Personally, I hold the belief that shooting bus drivers should come under the heading of light diversion, but the statutes look at it differently and when one is shot a sheriff, or a policeman, or someone, sooner or later hears about it and becomes agitated. Nothing like that happens in this picture. But when Bob McKim steals some money and they think Hoot did it, a sheriff is dug up pronto. If *The Denver Dude* had not contained these few faults, and if a different story had been written for it, it might have been a pretty good picture. However, it is no worse than the ordinary run of Westerns and if you do not apply the rule of reason to it you may get some fun out of it. But if you do apply the rule of reason you will get a devil of a lot more, but not the same kind. (Hoot told me that if he liked my review of *The Denver Dude* he'd subscribe for *The Spectator*.)

* * *

Hoot Gibson and Douglas Fairbanks

OF COURSE, my feelings for *The Denver Dude* may have been influenced somewhat by the presence of someone in the seat behind me who chewed gum with vulgar ostentation and disgusting and audible persistency. But I do not believe that even without the mushy obligato I could have witnessed with approval a scene showing Hoot and his father meeting after a separation of five years. Although an early scene registers the father's pride in his son, the two come together near the end of the picture and do not exchange a handclasp or a word. They do not even look at one another. When Reeves Eason directed the scene he simply forgot that a reunion was due, but how did it get beyond the projection-room? One of the weird things about Westerns is the habit producers have of making them so silly that they can not appeal to anyone who thinks. Such pictures have spoiled one of the most profitable fields that producers could exploit. Western pictures could be shown to-day in the biggest first-run houses and would be recognized as among the screen headliners if they had not degenerated into the wholly impossible things that masquerade under their name. They have the whole out-

doors as a background, the glorious scenery that our West can boast, red blooded men and women, elemental emotions, deeds of daring, great riding, great thrills—everything that a motion picture audience could ask for. They could provide the kind of entertainment that would thrill the moron and intrigue the intelligentsia, enjoying the widest appeal of any class of pictures, if only brains were exercised in their making. Charlie Rogers recognizes this, and, with Ken Maynard as star, is turning out Westerns with common sense stories. The *Overland Stage* is entertaining enough to please any audience on earth. I told Douglas Fairbanks the other day that a real Western should be his next picture. It was after a luncheon at which Dr. Hugo Reisenfeldt and I had as our opponents in an argument Doug, Joe Schenck and Fred Niblo, and I did not have sufficient eloquence left to uphold vigorously my contention about the Western, but I since have thought of a dozen reasons I might have advanced to support my theory that Doug, in a real, old-time Western, done with the care for detail that characterizes all his work and on the magnitude that his recent productions have achieved; with a sensible story, having both gripping drama and real comedy, and scenery that would give the production a sweep as broad as our plains, could give the public a picture that not only would make him another fortune and add to his reputation, but also would restore to Westerns in general the dignity that used to be theirs and should be still. Doug draws the smartest audiences wherever pictures are shown. Can't you imagine the thrill a Piccadilly audience would get out of a Western presented as he would present it? And, anyway, what is there left for Doug to do? He has done about everything in set building that the human mind can conceive. Now he should use the sets that nature built.

* * *

Tom Meighan Sinks Just a Little Deeper

ONE of *The Spectator's* rules of conduct is to be fair. In my review of *The Popular Sin* in the last issue I said that apparently the Paramount Long Island studio had no new ideas in lighting. I wish to make a retraction. It has. In *The Canadian*, Tommy Meighan's latest, there is an extraordinary exhibition of lighting. Most of the scenes are laid in two rooms in a farm house. The rooms are devoid of any lamps or lighting fixtures, yet at night are lighted brilliantly. The hidden system throws a brilliant light on Tom's face, no matter which way he is facing, and also shines refulgently on the top of his head, at the same time throwing his full length shadow on the wall. The sun does even better than that during the day sequences. Simultaneously it throws two shadows of Tom, each on a different wall. I take off my hat to the studio. It has done something in the lighting line that even God can't do. There are some snappy close-ups in *The Canadian*. There is one of Tom smoking his pipe, followed by one of a girl washing dishes, followed by one of Tom smoking his pipe, followed by one of a girl washing dishes, followed by one of Tom smoking his pipe, followed by one of a girl washing dishes, followed by one of Tom finishing his smoke, followed by one of the girl finishing the dishes. They are terribly exciting. You can see the smoke rising from Tom's pipe and the girl's hands moving in the dishpan. In one of them Tom appears to be thinking. The girl has a tough

year on a farm, but not tough enough to affect her high-heeled slippers, silk stockings or marcel. A firm of London lawyers, which signs its name after "Yours very truly," an expression never used by a firm of London lawyers, sends her a check for five hundred pounds to the distant Canadian farm. The check is not "crossed", as is the habit in England, and, anyway, is something that lawyers in London would not be idiots enough to send to Canada, when drawn on a London bank, for no one in Canada would cash it. The *London Daily Mail* subscribed for *The Spectator* the other day and forwarded a check drawn on J. P. Morgan & Co., New York. The lawyers in the picture would have sent exchange. But the girl starts off for the railway station with no cash, with nothing but the check with which to buy her ticket. I think I have seen a more hopelessly impossible picture than *The Canadian*, but not during the last fifteen years.

* * *

Heart Interest in Catalina Contest

WHEN he was introducing George Young at *Grauman's Egyptian* on the occasion of the presentation of the \$25,000 check to the channel swim winner, Fred Niblo referred to the young Canadian's mother and everyone applauded, including the man sitting directly in front of me. Three years ago he was a big man in one studio and now is a big man in another. It was just about three years ago that I submitted to him a story based on the love that existed between a mother in poor circumstances and her eighteen-year-old son. He was good enough to read it himself and afterwards he told me at length just why it would not do at all. The love that exists between a mother and her boy was not screen material, he said. It was something in which an audience could not be made interested. He proved everything he said—and the other night he applauded when Fred Niblo referred to the love that existed between seventeen-year-old George Young and his mother. All the world is applauding the same thing. It is the mother that makes the Young story dramatic. Do you imagine that if Norman Ross, the famous athlete, had won the race the thrill of it would have circled the globe? By no means. It would have been only a sporting event. But because this unknown youngster impressed the world with the sincerity of his love for his mother, and because the newspapers carried stories about the mother worrying about the possibility of her boy catching cold, George Young becomes the hero of the outstanding story of the century. This bears out what I said in a previous *Spectator*, that the public wants some real, old fashioned sentiment and that picture producers would be wise if they made some effort to cater to that want. But they will not. As a whole, the industry is incapable of learning anything. The reason for the amazing interest in the victor of the channel swim can be discovered only by a process of reasoning beyond the mental capacity of the industry to perform. The executive who sat in front of me applauded, but if you tried to sell him a story based on the sentiment he applauded he would pull gross figures on you to prove that by no possibility could a picture made from such a story prove to be a box office winner. It's sex stuff that the public wants, my boy, with a leaning towards war stories and spectacles. As for a mother's love for a kid, a boy who has no sex appeal—it would be a flop.